



theWindow

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God in the City

Preston Graham



from the Pastor

The headline in the *Yale Daily News* read, “Management student attacked with brick.” The article chronicled a rather bizarre series of events that occurred on a city street of New Haven around 8:30 p.m. The incident involved a first year School of Management student who was chased by two adolescents. The student required stitches

for a one-inch laceration after a young male threw a brick at him, hitting him just above the eyebrow. Of course you are thinking, what is so out of the ordinary about this—crime in the city, that is? Well, to be honest, nothing—yet. However, the article further noted how “the boy and his friend continued to pursue the student after the attack until his yelling drew attention from residents of Mansfield Street.” “There were some kind folks at the end of the street,” he said. “I’m certainly grateful for that.”

As it happened, the “residents” were a CPC fellowship group of about twelve people who were meeting in the neighborhood at the time. This is their version:

As we were discussing prayer requests, we heard two very loud cries for help. Within seconds, Chris was out on the balcony and three other men in our group were on the street, ready to help (one of them waving a broomstick in his hand). They arrived just in time to see someone running up the street and another man bleeding. It seems that two guys had assaulted the man with a brick, hitting him in the forehead. They were most likely after his wallet and perhaps his car. The man who had been assaulted was bleeding badly, and Elaine (a nurse at Yale-New Haven Hospital) went down to apply first aid as we waited for the ambulance to come. The police and paramedics arrived several minutes later and took down the report. The man was taken by ambulance to University Health Services. Elaine drove his car behind the ambulance so he would have it when he was done with treatment, and Chris followed Elaine to drive her home.

As our brothers and sisters were emboldened by their concentrated faith and numbers as believers in the city, I am reminded of a couple of things. For one, to be sure, life in the city is too often associated with “Sex and the City” or depicted as crime in the city with too little recognition for grace in the city or benevolence in the city. If you think about it, cities are people concentrated. If there is sin in people, cities will of course feel and taste more like sin concentrated than less populated areas do. But sadly, this is where our perception of the city stops—perhaps

especially for those of us who don’t live in the city. We often fail to hear much about the reciprocal reality of cities—that where there is grace in people, cities will of course feel and taste like grace concentrated! The event on the street that night simultaneously accentuated what is bad and good about cities. People concentrated will lead to a concentration of cultural decadence, but not so as to overshadow the concentrations of cultural grace. If our city is known for its degenerate graffiti, for instance, it is also known for its regenerate high arts and fine cuisine. We ought readily to apply this reality to the moral realm.

But there is more to this story than mere demographic commentary. We are all the more reminded of why we should all desire God in the city. I think back a few years to the early phases of our church building project, when a city official unashamedly spoke out against our quest to be in the city, declaring, “we have too many churches in New Haven as it is!” My response was to remind him of the high cost of sin in the city compared to the high value of free grace in the city. As Christians, we are reminded of just how special it is to participate in a regional vision for God in the city. Whether we live in downtown New Haven or the surrounding towns, we are all part of a greater vision to see God in the city. The city is anywhere that there is a concentration of culture, whether intellectual, social, or demographic. And our mission is to take strategic advantage of people concentrated for the sake of the gospel concentrated! The book of Acts is the story of God in the city (Jerusalem), even as the city concentrated the power of the gospel so as to reach “the ends of the earth” (Acts 1:8).

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Going . . . Not Knowing

Diane Miller



Briefings

These words were the title of a devotional an encouraging friend shared with me before I left Miami years ago. I was leaving the church and the friends who had challenged and supported me in faith for seven years and had no idea where I was headed next. The devotional used the story of Abraham as an example of someone who set out on a journey not based on confidence in a specific

knowledge of what lay ahead, but based on faith in the One who was guiding him. Involvement in missions, I sometimes think, is much the same, often involving going . . . but not knowing.

Personally, I like planning. My father's influence in my life is obvious in this regard. His detailed, color-coded itineraries for road trips are legendary to family and friends. He has passed on to me a love for maps, an excitement at considering what the opportunities along the road might be, a pleasure in looking at the details and coming up with the "best" plan. The internet now makes it possible for both of us to spend hours poring over the possibilities and indulging our passion for planning. Involvement in the mission team here at CPC gives me one more excuse.



Small group members enjoy fellowship after Bible study.

Participation in short-term mission trips certainly does involve planning. Mission to the World, the missions arm of the Presbyterian Church in America, focuses on cross-cultural word and deed ministries with the goal of seeing churches raised up among believers of every people group. Coordinators at MTW work with missionaries and churches throughout the world to develop opportunities for people to seek the furtherance of God's Kingdom through short-term missions projects. The missions team here at CPC reviews the opportunities available and makes a recommendation to the Servant Leader Board and Session about which trips to pursue, attempting to match the gifts and needs of our local body with the gifts and needs of the people we would be working with. Once a decision has been made, more specific planning takes place, with help from MTW, which provides logistical support and a framework for team training. Team members commit hours to preparing for "going" with as much "knowing" as possible, learning about the local culture, discussing how to share the gospel when opportunities arise,

identifying gifts and skills, coordinating how these gifts might be utilized during the project, and considering what challenges might lie ahead and how to deal with them faithfully.



Kids enjoy relaxing together on a recent Terrific Tuesday.

And yet despite all this planning, if you were to ask any of the Guatemala team members, I think you would find that they would express some anxiety. Why? I would guess that it comes from a sense of "not knowing." We plan, prepare, and pray, and yet questions still arise: What will it be like? Will I be able to communicate with anyone? Do I have any skills that will actually be useful? What if I get sick? What if I offend someone because I don't like the food? What if I am not comfortable talking with someone about the gospel? What if I really don't like the people I'm working with? Am I spiritually mature enough? What if I don't feel a spiritual high?

The reality is that even with the best planning, missions trips will not always go as planned. In the end, we come back to the realization that it is not the "what" or "how" or "when" that will have prepared us, but the "who." As our team has been reminded in its training sessions, we are not taking God or the gospel anywhere new. God is already there. What a comforting reminder! Through His wonderful providence, we will have an opportunity to catch a glimpse of how He is at work in another community. By His grace, we will seek to be faithful in service but can be confident that even in the midst of our human failures, His work will continue to be accomplished. We may not know the answers to any of our questions before we go, but because of God's faithfulness, we can plan on seeing our faith grow as he leads us through the experience.

In the end, we come back to the realization that it is not the "what" or "how" or "when" that will have prepared us, but the "who."

There are many unknowns involved in planning a short-term missions trip. But are we really going . . . without knowing? In many ways, the answer is yes. But we also have as a guide the One who has called Himself the Good Shepherd, the One who knows the plans He has for us, the One who has numbered the hairs on our heads. As we each consider our opportunities for missions, whether it be in a small mountain village in Guatemala, at the local shelter for the homeless, or in the home of the family in crisis next door, would you ask with me, knowing that God is already there, do we really need to know more? ❖

Making a Joyful Noise

Hsing-ay Hsu Kellogg



As our music team and choir become more established and polished, we are able to use our gifts to reach out to the community. Three wonderful musical experiences made this spring more memorable.

On March 30 our fearless band leaders Trip Lehn and Daniel Kellogg led members of the *Into thy Light* CD cast (plus Peter McHenry on drums) at the monthly Yale All-Campus worship. Along with our CD repertoire, Trip also added several worship songs that were favorites with the Yalies. Trip and Dan packed all the sound equipment they could into their cars and headed to campus. We had a wonderful evening worshipping and praying with students of many denominations and introducing them to a large variety of CPC's worship songs.

Wednesdays in April were extraordinarily exciting for the CPC musicians. I had the pleasure of organizing our second annual April Musicfest, a series of lunchtime concerts. This year the theme was conversations in chamber music. Joe Shields, Michelle Lee, and I brought in professional chamber musicians, who generously donated their talents to help make CPC an attractive new member of the arts community in New Haven. The First Church of Christ in Milford also graciously lent us a beautiful hand-made harpsichord for one of the concerts. Harpsichord curator Judith Hunt helped me move the instrument and made several visits to keep it in tune.



CPC and the community enjoy a lunchtime concert in April.

As part of our publicity efforts, Dan Kellogg led a group of church members into the business community to post flyers in local businesses and personally invite passers-by to the concerts. These efforts led to a significant growth in attendance and allowed members of the church to interact with our neighbors on a larger scale than we have in the past. Thank you to the many people who helped in this ambitious outreach! Because we are doing more events, the church is establishing a CPC Publicity Team to help communicate with the media and community. Please contact me if you would like to help.

The CPC choir recently made its community debut at Hilltop Health Center, a beautiful nursing home that houses CPC

member Mary Cozza. I am glad to report Mary is recovering very well from her hip injury and was in very high spirits during our visit. We sang a wide range of choral pieces, from a bluesy arrangement of the popular "Amazing Grace" to the highly difficult a cappella "Alleluia" by Randall Thompson. In addition to a small upright piano, I had help from string players Demetrios Braddock and Elena, Adele, and Ethan Zitzman. So many Zitzmans! Remember their wonderful CPC family debut at our Arts Show? The Ceryniks and Lempkes joined together in a beautiful rendition of "It is Well." Yvonne and Arijana Lempke graciously and courageously stood in front of the audience to lead them in singing the refrain.

I will end by thanking Chris and Rebekah Prokop for being an amazing support to our musicians—they attended all three projects! Finally, I couldn't possibly write to you without inviting you to get involved. There is a way for everyone to be involved in music, whether it's by helping to lead worship or coming to support our CPC kids at the Arts Show. Music brings people together! ❖

("God in the City" continued from page 1)

As we conclude a really great year at CPC, we can especially thank God for the rejuvenation many of us have felt this year in the discovery or rediscovery of the gospel. Through our series in the Ten Commandments, we have realized and experienced the truth of Paul's maxim over and over again—that related to the law and the gospel, where "sin increased, grace abounded all the more" (Rom. 5:20). The city is the perfect metaphor for this truth. Moreover, we can thank God for the many new "churches in miniature" that have formed and are being formed throughout the New Haven area in our small groups. Let's continue to pray that each will become more and more an outpost for God in the city.

We often fail to hear much about the reality that where there is grace in people, cities will feel and taste like grace concentrated!

For this to happen, we need all the gifts of the body participating. We will need more leaders, more mercy coordinators, more open homes, and more hospitality. More even than this, we will need an ever-increasing and powerful outpouring of God's spirit in our midst as mediated through the ministry of word, sacraments, and fellowship, even as this fellowship is corporately expressed through one-anothering that crosses all cultural divides. We will need more resources, both fiscal and human. These resources will be focused inward and outward as we pursue our vision, and we are continually grateful to the many who already support our vision and ministry throughout the world with the gifts that they give to CPC, Hope for New Haven, and RUF. And when sin concentrated weighs us down, we will need perseverance to experience the gospel concentrated by a kind of grace that remembers with Paul, "but he said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for power is made perfect in weakness.' So, I will boast all the more gladly of my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may dwell in me" (2 Corinthians 12:9). ❖

Missions Update

Diane Miller



CPC is participating this year in a short-term Impact trip to Guatemala through Mission to the World. The team currently consists of ten folks, who are busy raising support and planning and preparing as we try to be good stewards of the opportunity God has provided for us. The team will be departing June 26 and returning July 3, and while in the

mountains of Guatemala, will be supporting the work of John and Diana Lubeck, Bible translators who have worked among the Chorti' Indians for more than thirty years. The role of our team is still developing as we attempt to match our gifts with the needs of the church in Pelillo, but the focus will be on supporting their desire to provide Bible education and training. We may assist in construction projects involving the church sanctuary and the addition of an office to the Lubecks' home where Old Testament translation can take place. Several of us may also participate in medical work, Bible teaching, and activities for children.

CPC also has several students participating in other summer missions opportunities. Bobby Cardone will be working with college students in Mexico City, Leah Kelley will be traveling to East Asia, and Laura Wilhelm will go on a school project to Mexico. Won't you join those going through prayer? If you'd like to know more or offer financial support, please contact the church office or Diane Miller (dianem2001@msn.com).

A prior opportunity CPC had for "going...not knowing" was a trip in the summer of 1999 to Guanaja, a small island off the coast of Honduras. Preston led a team of six CPC members as part of the MTW response to a devastating hurricane that had struck the island. MTW continues to be active in Guanaja, developing leaders and ministries. A recent update indicates that more than 300 homes have been built through the efforts of MTW teams, and since then the work has grown to include Bible studies, evangelism, discipleship, children's programs, youth and young adult activities, mercy ministry, hosting interns, and continued coordination and oversight of construction and medical teams. An MTW Advance team is almost ready to launch a church plant on the island. Visit www.jandjnelms.com and www.home.earthlink.net/~mtkt6/ for more information on the work of the MTW team in Guanaja and recent photos. ❖

Pray for our missions project participants:

Barb, Chris, Laura, and Kevin Battista

Lei Chen Clay Daniel

Jason Klostreich Diane Miller

Marjorie Mitchell Jeff Wilhelm

Bobby Cardone Leah Kelley

Laura Wilhelm



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